

KEY DEVELOPMENT

GUERRILLAS AND TERRORISTS

Guerrilla warfare has existed for centuries, but it was the Chinese Communist leader Mao Zedong who, during the Chinese civil war, gave it its modern form. Mao gathered support within rural communities, and built a grass-roots force that he used to wage a campaign of armed harassment against the Chinese government. Mao later expanded his guerrilla forces to conduct conventional military operations.

Guerrilla war, inspired by leaders such as Mao and, later, Cuban revolutionary Fidel Castro, gained enormous influence in the postwar period, when nationalists in Asia and Africa were fighting for independence from European colonial rule – notably the Algerian nationalists against the French in Algiers. However, the emergence of the Cold War (see pp. 384–85) complicated matters, as it tended to polarize all such conflicts into a broader struggle of East versus West.

CONFLICT IN VIETNAM

This polarization was epitomized by events during the war in Vietnam, which saw the development of a new model of guerilla warfare. Adopting Mao's strategy as an initial template, a Vietnamese Nationalist–Communist coalition rose up against the French administration in 1945. Using classic guerrilla hit-and-run tactics, their lightly armed, highly mobile forces wore down the French army, and then, in 1954, defeated it in a pitched battle at Dien Bien Phu. The subsequent peace settlement

was followed by elections, which the US sabotaged for fear that North Vietnamese Communist leader Ho Chi Minh would win. This, in turn, was the trigger for hostilities between the Communist north and the US-backed south.

At first, it seemed inevitable that the better-equipped US would crush the insurgency with superior weapons and air power. The Vietnamese Communists received extensive military assistance from China and the Soviet Union; although this consisted mainly of World War II-era rifles and machine-guns to begin with, the Vietnamese were also tenacious and focused on their objectives, while the Americans lacked a coherent counterinsurgency strategy. Years of bitter guerrilla warfare failed to secure victory for the US; disillusioned and exhausted, it withdrew its forces in 1972 – a prelude to a North Vietnamese takeover of the country.

With the demise of colonial empires by the mid-1970s, guerrilla conflicts became more diverse. The US sponsored its own insurgent



KEY FIGURE

MAO ZEDONG
1893–1976

The son of a farmer, Mao went to university in Beijing, where he studied the works of Marx, and co-founded the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) in 1921. In contrast to the conventional Communist reliance on urban workers, Mao mobilized the rural peasants, who became the bedrock of his military revolution.



▲ After defeating the Nationalists in 1949, Mao dominated Chinese political life until his death in 1976.

◀ GUERRILLA WEAPONS

Iraqi insurgents often use RPGs (an abbreviation of the Russian for “manually operated anti-tank grenade launcher”), and improvised explosive devices (IEDs), which are cheap but effective against occupying forces’ vehicles. Other tactics include sniping, mortar strikes, and suicide bombings.